

*Post* article predicted, “Many of the occupations projected to add the most jobs by 2024 pay too little to cover rent.”

When I first read it, I was surprised by this sweeping information, but Edin and Schaefer wouldn’t be. In fact, they wrote, the number of people living on this amount of money doubled by 2011. “Although the rate of growth was highest among African Americans and Hispanics, nearly half the 2-dollar-a-day poor were white,” Edin and Schaefer found.

So what are these families to do? Not only are they battling increasingly terrible living conditions, but they also face horrible negative stereotypes about being lazy or conniving. “These moms don’t play by the rules. These moms don’t control their fertility and they keep having children that they can’t afford. These moms are just sitting at home collecting the checks,” said Northwestern Sociology and African American Studies professor Celeste Watkins-Hayes as examples of some of the preposterous reasons people give for not liking government assistance or the people who need it. “[It’s] a sexy political tool to get people that are just above welfare, people who are working class, or even people who are middle class to say, ‘Oh the reason why I’m economically struggling isn’t because of what the powerful are doing, it’s because of these women who can’t get their act together,’” Watkins-Hayes said.

Since when do our taxes have a morality clause? “We shouldn’t pay for other people’s health care if we’re healthy” and “We shouldn’t have to pay for irresponsible people” or “Health care isn’t a right, it’s a commodity.” My counterpoint to the person saying these things is this: “I hope you’d say the same thing if you ever lost everything.”



In *2 Dollars a Day*, Edin wrote, “One way the poor pay for government aid is with their time.” In an eye-opening section of the book, she follows a woman named Modonna and her daughter, residents of a homeless shelter who often go hungry on the weekends. Edin joined her as she waited in a line around the block to get into the Department of Human Services offices. First: You wait in that line. Then: You get a number. Wait. Get called in to see a caseworker. Provide